

TABLE 2.8 : AVERAGE BIRTH RATE, DEATH RATE AND RATE OF NATURAL INCREASE FOR THE PERIOD 1963-1971 BY ETHNIC GROUPS - SRI LANKA

	Birth rate per 1000 persons	Death rate per 1000 persons	Rate of natural in- crease per cent
All Ethnic Groups	35.8	8.2	2.76
Sinhalese	31.7	7.4	2.43
Ceylon Tamils	34.4	9.1	2.53
Ceylon Moors	40.7	9.4	3.13
Indian Tamils	26.7	11.2	1.55
Burghers	20.3	7.9	1.24

In the case of the Sinhalese among whom migration may be negligible except for a few going abroad for higher studies and employment, the average rate of natural increase for the period 1963-71 is seen to coincide with the average annual rate of growth for the same period as derived from the Census figures. The rate of growth of the Ceylon Tamils was slightly lower than the rate of natural increase. Migration out of the country for higher studies and employment during the period could account for a part of the small difference. Although the Ceylon Tamils had a slightly high birth rate than the Sinhalese their death rate too was correspondingly higher. The Ceylon Moors had the highest birth rate as well as the highest rate of natural increase. The rate of natural increase of 3.13 percent is however lower than the intercensal rate of growth of 3.5 percent for the intercensal period 1946-53 derived from the Census figures.

2.5 Population growth in the districts

Table 2.9 shows the population of each district at the Censuses of 1946, 1953, 1963 and 1971 and the average annual rates of growth during each intercensal period. The growth of the population of the different districts has by no means been uniform. In some districts the rate of growth has been higher than for the Island as a whole while in the others it has been lower. Very high rates of growth exceeding 5.0 percent have been recorded in Vavuniya district (1946-53 and 1953-63), Trincomalee (1953-63) and Anuradhapura and⁷ Polonnaruwa districts combined (1946-53 and 1953-63). During the period 1963-71 high rates of growth exceeding 4 percent were recorded in Moneragala (4.7%) Polonnaruwa (4.5%) Anuradhapura (4.1%) and Vavuniya (4.1%) Districts. However, as in the case of the Island as a whole the rates of growth of each district have generally declined between 1946 and 1971.

The different districts have experienced different rates of growth mainly because of differences in the extent of inter-district migration. In general, districts with rates of growth higher than the Island's rate are ones into which there has been some net in-migration drawn from the other districts with lower rates of growth. Districts with significant in-migration are Hambantota, Mannar, Vavuniya, Batticaloa, Amparai, Trincomalee (except during 1946-53) Anuradhapura, Polonnaruwa and Moneragala. Districts with significant out-migration are Kalutara, Kandy, Nuwara Eliya, Galle, Matara, Jaffna and Kegalle.⁸

⁷ Polonnaruwa district formed a part of Anuradhapura district at the Census of 1953.

⁸ For further discussion, see United Nations ESCAP "Comparative Study of Population change and agricultural change: Case Study of Sri Lanka". Asian Population Studies No.23 Bangkok